

Plenty of First Basemen in Race for All-Star Team

(First of a series. Clip and save to use in voting for "Best of the Braves" Contest to be run in this paper during the 1960 Northern League season.)

By CLELL BUZZELL

No first baseman for Eau Claire in the Northern League ever went on to big league stardom.

But that doesn't mean there aren't plenty of candidates for the first base post on the all-star team Eau Claire fans are going to pick this 25th anniversary season.

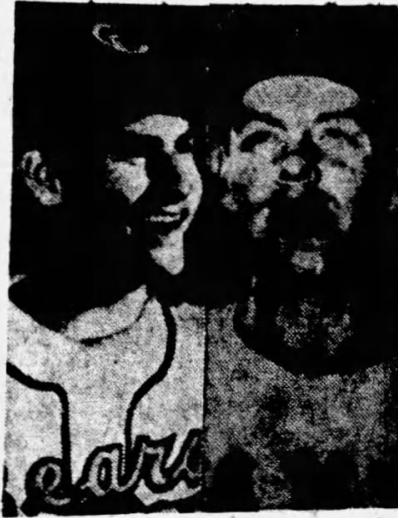
In fact, with no one stand-out candidate, voting for first baseman should be a wide-open scrap.

AT LEAST two former Eau Claire first basemen made it to the majors. Joe LaFata of the 1941 Bears and Clint Hartung of the 1942 Bears both played with the New York Giants.

But you don't have to go back that far to find good candidates. Doug Smith of the 1958 Braves hit .336, second high in the league, with 18 homers and 80 runs batted in. He fielded .985 and was one of the best hustlers in the lot.

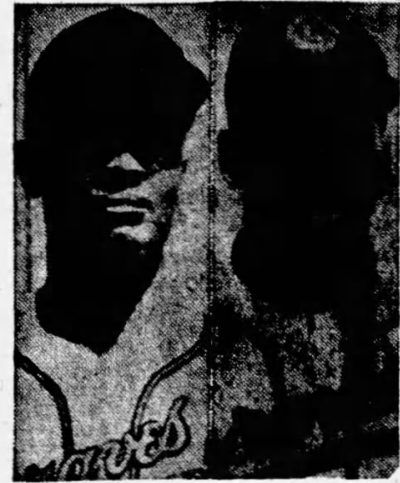
Just one year earlier Howie Rouse, a converted catcher, hit .298, belted 16 homers and drove in 93 runs. He fielded .986.

If you're an old-time fan, you may cast a vote for Dan Collins, steady hitter and fielder, who held down the initial sack for Eau Claire in the rough and rugged seasons of 1933-34-35.



Warner

Hartung



Rouse

Smith

Hartung, the Texas phenom who failed to make the grade in the majors, belted the ball at a .358 clip in his 63 games here in 1942, hitting 12 homers and driving in 61 runs. His fielding was less spectacular at .974.

LaFata was a slick-fielding star of Manager Rosy Ryan's 1941 champions, one of the most popular ever to play here, but not a great hitter.

Another sparkling fielder was Jack Daniels, a .274 hitter for Manager Hugh Wise's 1947 Bears.

HARRY WARNER was one of Eau Claire's top RBI men with 90 in 112 games for the 1950 Braves. He hit .285 and had 12 homers.

Don (Whitey) Anderson, another highly popular first sacker, hit .298 in the 1939 season.

Other favorites might include Paul Snyder, who hit .330 and fielded .980 in 70 games last season; Bill McColly, an aggressive player in 1955-56; Don Steger, who held down first base two seasons for Manager Andy Cohen in 1948-49; and Steve Magula, rough-and-ready 1946 first sacker.

Also on the first base list are Ray Harbaugh, 1953-54; Dick Engquist, 1952; Bud Pfeiffer, 1951; and Frank Scalise, 1936-37.

Collins held a league record for many seasons by accepting 20 chances and making 20 putouts in a game July 3, 1935.

Anderson shared a league mark by stealing five bases in one game Sept. 7, 1941.